

HiveForce Labs

THREAT ADVISORY



ATTACK REPORT

APT36's Dark Playbook: Crimson Codes and Crisis Lures Strike India

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A1

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Summary

Active Since: 2013

Threat Actor: APT36 (alias Mythic Leopard, Transparent Tribe, ProjectM, TEMP.Lapis, Copper Fieldstone, Earth Karkaddan, STEPPY-KAVACH, Green Havildar, APT-C-56, Storm-0156)

Malware: Crimson RAT, Poseidon, ElizaRAT

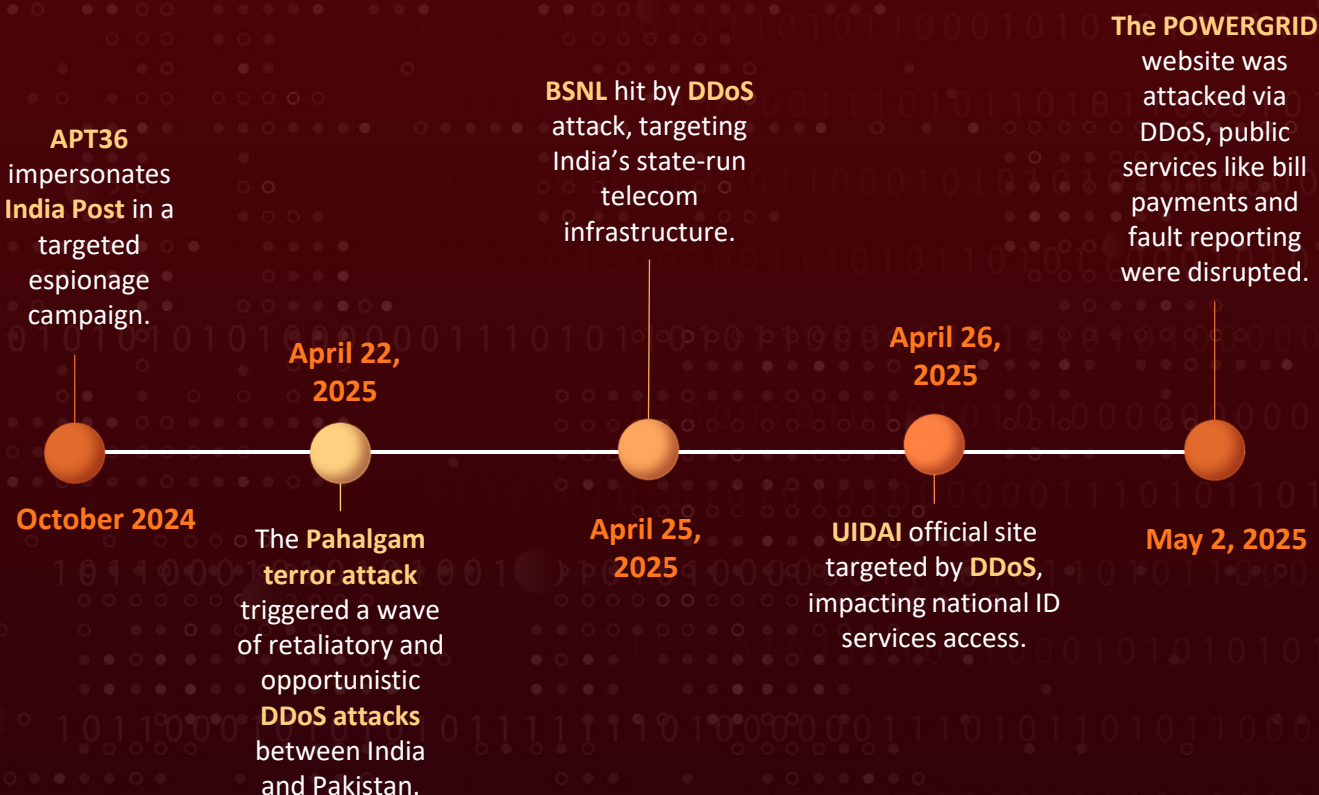
Targeted Country: India

Targeted Industries: Government, Military, Defense, Aerospace, Education, Media, Energy, Telecommunications

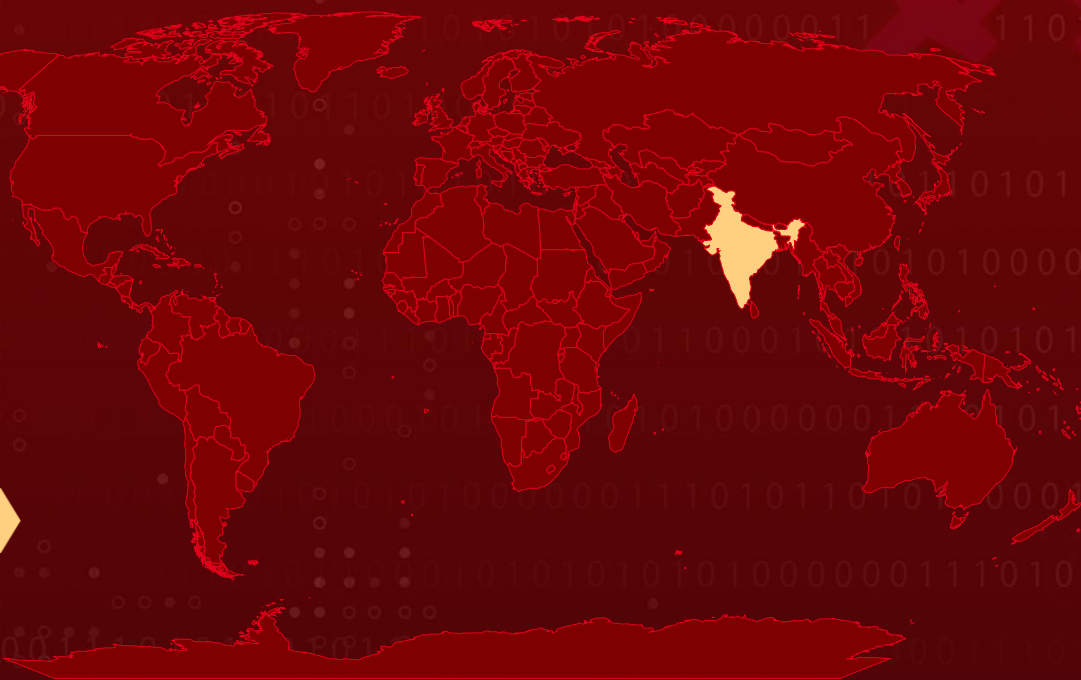
Affected Products: Windows, Linux, Android

Attack: APT36 has relentlessly sharpened its arsenal, exploiting geopolitical flashpoints to drive precision espionage operations against India. From crisis-themed phishing lures to agile, cross-platform malware, their tactics reveal a ruthless fusion of technical sophistication and psychological warfare. Their latest campaigns underscore just how swiftly cyber conflict can ignite when national tensions erupt.

Attack Timeline



✂ Attack Regions



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Attack Details

#1

APT36, also known as Transparent Tribe, is a Pakistan-based APT group active since at least 2013. The group primarily conducts cyber-espionage operations targeting Indian entities, including government agencies, military personnel, defense contractors, and academic institutions.

#2

Over time, they have evolved their tactics, adopting cross-platform programming languages such as Python, Golang, and Rust, while exploiting legitimate services like Telegram, Discord, Slack, and Google Drive for command-and-control (C2) communications. In October 2024, APT36 escalated its operations with a highly targeted campaign impersonating India's national postal service.

#3

The group set up a fake IndiaPost website to compromise both Windows and Android users. Mobile visitors were prompted to download a malicious Android application that requested excessive permissions and covertly exfiltrated data via a fraudulent Google Analytics domain.

#4

Desktop users, meanwhile, were lured into granting clipboard access and downloading a PDF labeled ClickFix, which contained further malicious instructions. At the core of APT36's malware arsenal is Crimson RAT, complemented by Poseidon for Linux systems and ElizaRAT for Windows.

#5

Following the Pahalgam terror attack on April 22, 2025, APT36 rapidly intensified its cyber operations. Within days, they circulated phishing documents titled "Action Points & Response by Govt Regarding Pahalgam Terror Attack.pdf", attributed to the alias Kalu Badshah. These documents embedded phishing links that redirected victims to counterfeit domains designed to harvest credentials from Indian government officials.

#6

To complement these phishing documents, APT36 deployed malicious, macro-enabled PowerPoint add-in files (PPAM). These files installed Crimson RAT after determining the victim's Windows version. Disguised with deceptive filenames like WEISTT.jpg, the malware granted attackers over 22 remote capabilities, including file theft, screen capture, command execution, and persistence via registry alterations.

#7

Notably, these payloads were compiled a day before the actual terror incident, indicating a calculated, premeditated operation. Between April 25 and May 2, 2025, India experienced a wave of DDoS attacks targeting critical infrastructure, including PowerGrid, UIDAI, and BSNL. These attacks, executed using NTP and NetBIOS reflection techniques, disrupted digital services while providing a distraction and operational cover for APT36's phishing campaigns.

Recommendations



Be Wary of Unfamiliar Sources: Always verify URLs and email sources before clicking, especially if they come from unfamiliar or unexpected senders. Exercise caution with downloads, particularly from unverified sources, pirated content, or suspicious links that could lead to malware or phishing schemes designed to exploit vulnerabilities.



Harden Web Servers and Application Configurations: Ensure web servers and application configurations are hardened according to best security practices. Disable unused ports and services, enforce secure coding standards, and apply the latest patches to mitigate vulnerabilities that attackers may exploit in their phishing or malware delivery methods.



Network Segmentation & Zero Trust Implementation: Segment critical infrastructure to isolate sensitive data and limit lateral movement. Implement Zero Trust Network Access (ZTNA) by enforcing identity-based policies rather than traditional perimeter security.



Monitor for Unusual IP Geofencing: Implement IP geofencing and access controls based on the geographical location of login attempts. If an attacker uses spoofed or compromised credentials, they may attempt to access the system from unusual locations, something easily flagged by monitoring for geographical anomalies.



Potential **MITRE ATT&CK** TTPs

<u>TA0042</u> Resource Development	<u>TA0001</u> Initial Access	<u>TA0002</u> Execution	<u>TA0003</u> Persistence
<u>TA0004</u> Privilege Escalation	<u>TA0005</u> Defense Evasion	<u>TA0007</u> Discovery	<u>TA0009</u> Collection
<u>TA0011</u> Command and Control	<u>TA0010</u> Exfiltration	<u>T1598</u> Phishing for Information	<u>T1070</u> Indicator Removal
<u>T1566</u> Phishing	<u>T1059</u> Command and Scripting Interpreter	<u>T1059.001</u> PowerShell	<u>T1204</u> User Execution
<u>T1546</u> Event Triggered Execution	<u>T1546.013</u> PowerShell Profile	<u>T1430</u> Location Tracking	<u>T1409</u> Stored Application Data
<u>T1115</u> Clipboard Data	<u>T1573</u> Encrypted Channel	<u>T1071</u> Application Layer Protocol	<u>T1598.003</u> Spearphishing Link
<u>T1583.001</u> Domains	<u>T1566.001</u> Spearphishing Attachment	<u>T1204.001</u> Malicious Link	<u>T1059.005</u> Visual Basic
<u>T1547.001</u> Registry Run Keys / Startup Folder	<u>T1033</u> System Owner/User Discovery	<u>T1057</u> Process Discovery	<u>T1082</u> System Information Discovery

<u>T1083</u> File and Directory Discovery	<u>T1005</u> Data from Local System	<u>T1113</u> Screen Capture	<u>T1041</u> Exfiltration Over C2 Channel
<u>T1218.005</u> Mshta	<u>T1071.001</u> Web Protocols	<u>T1204.002</u> Malicious File	<u>T1027</u> Obfuscated Files or Information
<u>T1036.005</u> Match Legitimate Name or Location	<u>T1070.004</u> File Deletion	<u>T1056.001</u> Keylogging	<u>T1583</u> Acquire Infrastructure
<u>T1027.013</u> Encrypted/Encoded File	<u>T1566.002</u> Spearphishing Link	<u>T1608.004</u> Drive-by Target	<u>T1608</u> Stage Capabilities

✂ Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

TYPE	VALUE
IPv4	88[.]222[.]245[.]211, 93[.]127[.]133[.]58, 78[.]40[.]143[.]189, 37[.]221[.]64[.]134, 45[.]141[.]58[.]224, 45[.]141[.]59[.]167, 78[.]40[.]143[.]98, 84[.]54[.]51[.]12, 45[.]141[.]58[.]33, 176[.]65[.]143[.]215, 45[.]141[.]59[.]72, 192[.]64[.]118[.]76, 185[.]117[.]90[.]212
MD5	c4fb60217e3d43eac92074c45228506a, 172fff2634545cf59d59c179d139e0aa, 7b08580a4f6995f645a5bf8addbefa68, 1b71434e049fb8765d528ecabd722072, c4f591cad9d158e2fbb0ed6425ce3804, 5f03629508f46e822cf08d7864f585d3, f5cd5f616a482645bbf8f4c51ee38958, fa2c39adbb0ca7aeab5bc5cd1ffb2f08, 00cd306f7cdcfef187c561dd42ab40f33, ca27970308b2fdeaa3a8e8e53c86cd3e, d946e3e94fec670f9e47aca186ecaabe, e18c4172329c32d8394ba0658d5212c2, 2fde001f4c17c8613480091fa48b55a0,

TYPE	VALUE
MD5	c1f4c9f969f955dec2465317b526b600, 026e8e7acb2f2a156f8afff64fd54066, fb64c22d37c502bde55b19688d40c803, 70b8040730c62e4a52a904251fa74029, 3efec6ffcbfe79f71f5410eb46f1c19e, B03211f6feccd3a62273368b52f6079d
IPv4:Port	93[.]127[.]133[.]58[:]1097, 93[.]127[.]133[.]58[:]17241, 93[.]127[.]133[.]58[:]19821, 93[.]127[.]133[.]58[:]21817, 93[.]127[.]133[.]58[:]23221, 93[.]127[.]133[.]58[:]27425, 104[.]129[.]27[.]14[:]8108, 104[.]129[.]27[.]14[:]16197, 104[.]129[.]27[.]14[:]19867, 104[.]129[.]27[.]14[:]28784, 104[.]129[.]27[.]14[:]30123
URLs	hxxps[:]//jkpolice[.]gov[.]in[.]kashmirattack[.]exposed/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//iaf[.]nic[.]in[.]ministryofdefenceindia[.]org/publications/default[.]htm, hxxps[:]//jkpolice[.]gov[.]in[.]kashmiraxxack[.]exposed/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]ministryofdefenceindia[.]org/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]departmentofdefenceindia[.]link/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]departmentofdefence[.]de/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]indiangov[.]download/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//indianarmy[.]nic[.]in[.]departmentofdefence[.]de/publications/publications-site-main/index[.]html, hxxps[:]//indianarmy[.]nic[.]in[.]ministryofdefenceindia[.]org/publications/publications-site-main/index[.]htm, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]briefcases[.]email/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]modindia[.]link/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]defenceindia[.]ltd/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]indiadefencedepartment[.]link/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]departmentofspace[.]info/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//email[.]gov[.]in[.]indiandefence[.]work/service/home/ e/, hxxps[:]//trade4wealth[.]in/admin/assets/js/, hxxps[:]//trade4wealth[.]in/admin/assets/css/default/sysinte[.]hta, hxxps[:]//jkpolice[.]gov[.]in[.]kashmirattack[.]exposed

TYPE	VALUE
SHA256	cbf74574278a22f1c38ca922f91548596630fc67bb234834d52557371b9abf5d, 287a5f95458301c632d6aa02de26d7fd9b63c6661af331dff1e9b2264d150d23, 7087e5f768acaad83550e6b1b9696477089d2797e8f6e3f9a9d69c77177d030e
Domains	email[.]gov[.]in[.]gov-in[.]mywire[.]org, Postindia[.]site, jkpolice[.]gov[.]in[.]kashmirattac[.]exposed, iaf[.]nic[.]in[.]ministryofdefenceindia[.]org, kashmirattack[.]exposed, ministryofdefenceindia[.]org, jkpolice[.]gov[.]in, jkpolice[.]gov[.]in[.]kashmirattack[.]exposed, email[.]gov[.]in[.]ministryofdefenceindia[.]org, email[.]gov[.]in[.]departmentofdefenceindia[.]link, email[.]gov[.]in[.]departmentofdefence[.]de, email[.]gov[.]in[.]briefcases[.]email, email[.]gov[.]in[.]modindia[.]link, email[.]gov[.]in[.]defenceindia[.]ltd, email[.]gov[.]in[.]indiadefencedepartment[.]link, email[.]gov[.]in[.]departmentofspace[.]info, email[.]gov[.]in[.]indiangov[.]download, indianarmy[.]nic[.]in[.]departmentofdefence[.]de, indianarmy[.]nic[.]in[.]ministryofdefenceindia[.]org, email[.]gov[.]in[.]indiandefence[.]work, email[.]gov[.]in[.]drdosurvey[.]info, email[.]gov[.]in[.]avtzyu[.]store
File Name	Report & Update Regarding Pahalgam Terror Attack.pdf, Report Update Regarding Pahalgam Terror Attack.pdf, Action Points & Response by Govt Regarding Pahalgam Terror Attack .pdf, J&K Police Letter Dated 17 April 2025.pdf, ROD on Review Meeting held on 10 April 2025 by Secy DRDO.pdf, RECORD OF DISCUSSION TECHNICAL REVIEW MEETING NOTICE, 07 April 2025 (1).pdf, MEETING NOTICE – 13th JWG meeting between India and Nepal.pdf, Agenda Points for Joint Venture Meeting at IHQ MoD on 04 March 2025.pdf, DO Letter Integrated HQ of MoD dated 3 March.pdf, Collegiate Meeting Notice & Action Points MoD 24 March.pdf, Letter to the Raksha Mantri Office Dated 26 Feb 2025.pdf, Alleged Case of Sexual Harassment by Senior Army Officer.pdf, Agenda Points of Meeting of Dept of Defence held at 11March 25.html,

TYPE	VALUE
File Name	Action Points of Meeting of Dept of Defence held at 10March 25.html, Agenda Points of Meeting of External Affairs Dept 10 March 25.pdf.html, Report & Update Regarding Pahalgam Terror Attack.ppam, sysinte.hta, WEISTT.jpg

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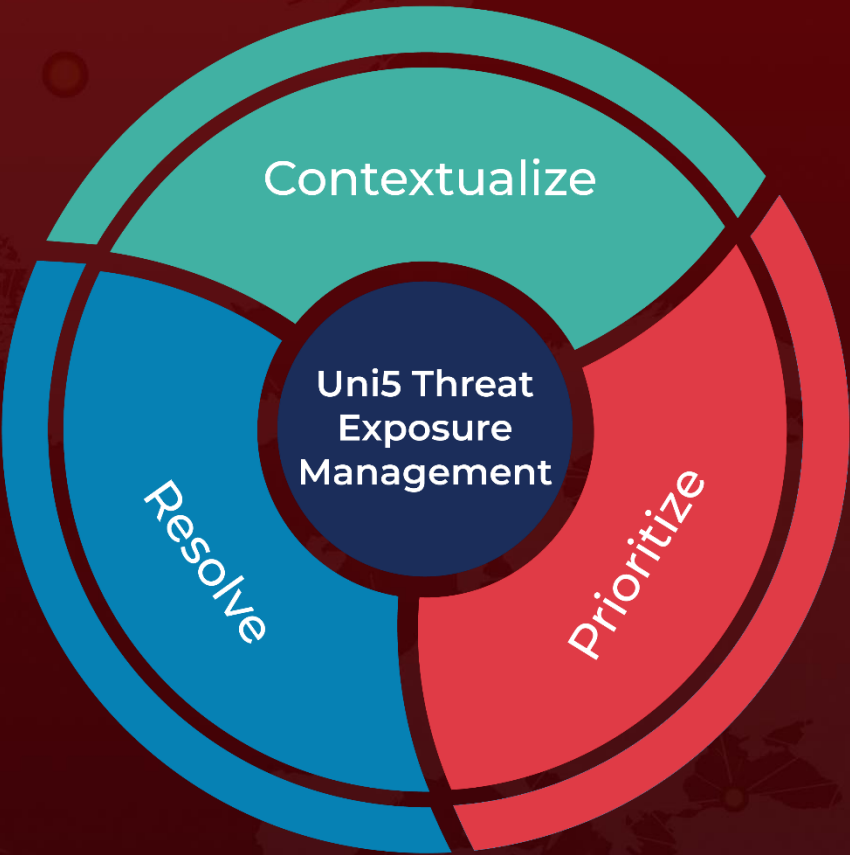
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<https://attack.mitre.org/groups/G0134/>

What Next?

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